

LEVEL STEPS



100 DAILY MEDITATIONS FOR FREEMASONS

JONTI MARKS

LEVEL STEPS



100 DAILY MEDITATIONS FOR FREEMASONS

JONTI MARKS

Level Steps.

100 Daily Meditations for Freemasons

Jonti Marks.

Copyright Jonti Marks 2004

This edition published by Jonti Marks at Smashwords

The right of Jonti Marks to be identified as the author of this work has been asserted in accordance with the Copyright, Designs and Patents Act 1988.

This ebook is licensed for your personal enjoyment only. This ebook may not be re-sold or given away to other people. If you would like to share this book with another person, please purchase an additional copy for each recipient. If you're reading this book and did not purchase it, or it was not purchased for your use only, then please return to your favorite ebook retailer and purchase your own copy. Thank you for respecting the hard work of this author.

masonicmeditations@gmail.com

Contents:

[Title Page](#)
[Copyright](#)
[Acknowledgements](#)
[Dedication](#)

Introduction

- 1: 'Enter in God's name...'
- 2: 'I would not give much for your Freemasonry...'
- 3: 'The three Great Lights...'
- 4: 'Therefore when we build...'
- 5: 'What are you doing?'
- 6: 'What do you mean by Masonry?'
- 7: '...in proportion to our capacities...'
- 8: 'You agree to be a good man...'
- 9: 'Masonry, therefore, is not a competitor with religion...'
- 10: 'How should Freemasons meet?'
- 11: 'Live on old monuments of the past...'
- 12: 'There is a perennial nobleness...'
- 13: 'That thing which I understand by real art...'
- 14: 'What is the first duty..?'
- 15: 'You alone...'
- 16: 'Masons unite...'
- 17: 'The level demonstrates...'
- 18: 'It should be understood by every Brother...'
- 19: 'FAITH...HOPE...CHARITY...'
- 20: 'May Freemasonry in every quarter of the globe...'
- 21: 'You agree to avoid private piques...'
- 22: 'Everyone who enters Freemasonry...'
- 23: 'Name the three grand principles...'
- 24: 'Brethren, this morally teaches us...'
- 25: 'Thought will not work...'
- 26: 'Learn something every day...'
- 27: '...as a Craftsman, you are expected...'
- 28: 'Do not pray for easy lives...'
- 29: 'All these charges you are to observe...'
- 30: '...a time will most assuredly come...'
- 31: 'He, of all men...'
- 32: 'As an Individual...'
- 33: 'Masonry recognizes the right of every man...'
- 34: 'Before God's footstool to confess...'
- 35: 'So far as I am acquainted...'
- 36: '...Masonry, according to the general acceptance of the term...'
- 37: '...and honourable it must be acknowledged to be...'
- 38: 'Grandeur of character...'
- 39: '...as in the previous degree...'
- 40: 'To steer the bark of this life...'
- 41: 'There is so much good in the worst of us...'
- 42: '...while some must rule and teach...'
- 43: 'They remind us that...'
- 44: '...you will also notice that a Brother's hands...'
- 45: 'In this world...'
- 46: 'The heights by great men reached and kept...'
- 47: 'Exchanging fragmentary news...'
- 48: 'By such exemplary conduct...'
- 49: '...a spirit of emulation prevails...'

50: '...thereby enabling you to exercise those talents...'
51: 'My real faith then is in a dream...'
52: 'Truth never yet fell dead in the streets...'
53: '... in giving him a virtuous and liberal education...'
54: 'Let us discard all this quibbling...'
55: '...admonishing us to be careful...'
56: 'Pendant to the four corners of the Lodge...'
57: 'Truth's tough. It will not break...'
58: '...to seek the solace of your own distress...'
59: 'Although our past achievements...'
60: 'It cannot be too strongly asserted...'
61: 'Our Lodges are supported by three great pillars...'
62: '...as a Craftsman, you are expected...'
63: 'Where were you first prepared..?'
64: 'That Masons are builders...'
65: 'Not what we give...'
66: 'I pray you with all earnestness...'
67: 'In all cases of difficulty and danger...'
68: '...Happy to meet...'
69: 'All preferment among masons...'
70: 'As Masons we should so act...'
71: 'Those three things...'
72: '...and from the foundation laid this evening...'
73: 'You agree to promote...'
74: 'The distinguishing characteristics...'
75: 'May our work, begun in Thee...'
76: 'What is Freemasonry?'
77: 'To all poor and distressed Masons...'
78: 'There is no truth more thoroughly established...'
79: 'A younger brother shall be instructed...'
80: '...ever remembering the intention...'
81: 'We deem the lowest service...'
82: 'There is no secret...'
83: 'Let a man's religion...'
84: 'It is not enough...'
85: '...a poor candidate...'
86: 'The earth constantly revolving on its axis...'
87: 'Men have been imprisoned...'
88: '...but let me assure you...'
89: 'He has achieved success...'
90: 'The Sacred Writings are to rule and govern our faith...'
91: '...now comes of his own free will...'
92: '...contemplate on your destiny...'
93: 'Your trust being in God...'
94: 'Freemasonry is no longer an exclusive and withdrawn body...'
95: 'We hope to arrive at the summit...'
96: 'If one advances confidently...'
97: 'The first condition of admission...'
98: '...to look beyond the narrow limits...'
99: 'Freemasonry not only inculcates the principles of love and benevolence...'

100: ‘...and may He continue to preserve our order...’
Afterword:

Acknowledgements:

Most of the quotations for this book were taken from Masonic Ritual or other Masonic texts. The author gratefully acknowledges the wisdom of those men who formulated the rituals and who added so much to the body of Masonic lore.

The writings of other authors (including 'Anon') are taken from 'A Treasury of Masonic Thought' edited by Carl Glick and published by Robert Hale, London. Although none of the works are copyright as such, the author gratefully acknowledges the work of Carl Glick in collecting together such a wealth of Masonic material and, of course, the work of the original writers themselves.

Dedication:

To the Brethren of Lodges Harmony, 3084 E.C. and Scotia, 1008 S.C. who, by their example, have taught me to love Masonic Ritual and to care enough to want to be a 'good Mason.' Also, to the Brethren of the Old Bromsgrovian Lodge, 5743 E.C., who have taken me under their wing.

To Malaika, Jesse and Sami.

To the memory of some of my favourite Freemasons: Peter Crouch and Anthony Sumner, and my grandfather, 'Brother Ben,' who taught me little about Freemasonry directly, but much about living a good life.

Introduction:

The idea behind this book is not an original one. It is inspired, with thanks and appreciation, by the many beautiful small books of philosophy, religion, poetry, thoughts and meditation that have become so popular recently. I love the principle they embody: of starting each day with a reading and a quiet thought, but however hard I try, I find it difficult to fully ‘fit into’ the category of any one of them. I am drawn to the discipline suggested in these books but have always longed for one more in tune with the framework of my own beliefs.

Freemasonry is not a substitute for religion. We are told time and again in our ritual, and its truth is self-evident, that we should not abandon our own beliefs for those of Freemasonry. Rather, we should use the symbols and meaning of the Craft to clothe our individual beliefs in the greater majesty of actions inspired by them. The principles of Freemasonry are lofty and fine and those of us who have chosen it as the outer form of our inner growth owe it to ourselves to attempt at least the discipline inherent in the idea of putting aside a few minutes each day to contemplate our inner foundations. Such a discipline cannot fail to make us act in a more focussed manner, with our true values informing our decisions instead of our baser impulses.

In our ritual we are enjoined to make ‘...a daily advancement in Masonic knowledge.’ How many of us do? How many of us have even realised that ‘Masonic knowledge’ is knowledge of the deepest self, and knowledge of God? The enjoiner is one meant to foster a more profound understanding of our natures. But daily? How?

There is an enormous wealth of Masonic writing, generally of an historical or a philosophical nature but there is remarkably little to inspire, on a daily basis, the living-out of our tenets in a busy, modern world.

From all of these threads, this book was born. The thoughts are my own and do not represent the thinking of any Masonic authority. My hope is that it will be a spring-board for discovery and a source of inspiration for other Masons, as well as an instrument of understanding for their families and friends. May it, with Freemasonry, add a little to the world by,

‘...diffusing the light of knowledge; aiding the strength of reason; dispensing the practice of virtue by lessening the aggregate of human

misery and vice, by extending the bounties of charity and the blessings of peace to every deserving object under heaven.'

JAM.
August 2004.

‘Enter in God’s Name, Fearing No Evil.’

-Inscription on the Temple Door,
Freemason’s Hall, Nairobi, Kenya

When we enter Freemasonry, we take a great deal on trust. Although we may have read something about the institution or spoken to friends - at least our proposer and seconder - there is a moment of great aloneness just before we enter the Temple to receive the benefit of Initiation. It is a moment when all of our privileges of rank and fortune in the ‘outside’ world avail us nothing. It is a moment of doubt, perhaps even of fear, when we wonder, deep down, what we are getting into. Will Freemasonry be all that we expect? Is it really the noble and honourable institution it professes to be or are we about to enter on a path that will actually take us away from our chosen course of self-betterment? Thinking back on that moment, we can discover that doubt, questioning, is a necessary step that drives us back on to the bedrock of our faith and trust.

And through faith, in God’s name, we move forward, secure and confident that it is He who guides our steps to this door, at this time.

‘I would not give much for your Freemasonry unless it can be seen. Lamps do not talk but they shine...So let your actions shine out your Masonry. Let the main sermon of your life be illustrated by your conduct, and it shall not fail to be illustrious.’

-Anon

We have a duty to our much maligned Brotherhood to be exemplary in our conduct, for we are the visible face of Freemasonry. Freemasonry will be judged by what we, as Freemasons, do. We should be mindful of this every day, every moment and so order our actions as to be a credit to the institution of which we claim to be so proud.

But that is not all. Like any system designed for the betterment of humankind, Freemasonry is useless unless it is lived. The precepts that it teaches have no meaning until they find expression in our daily actions. The true secret of Masonry is to be found here: in a life well lived, in a heart devoid of all malice and in a conscience clear in the knowledge that, ‘I have tried my best.’

*'The three Great Lights will guide our steps
Through life's uncertain way,
And bring us safe at length to see
The bright eternal day.'*

-Anon

The three 'Great Lights' are the Square, the Compasses and the Volume of the Sacred Law, the Bible. The Square represents, and is almost synonymous with, good conduct. It is within the Square that the whole Craft is said to be ordered. The Compasses express the bounds of our daily lives, the full circle of our actions. The Volume of the Sacred Law, being considered the word of God, is a clear source of inspiration and instruction as to how we should try to order our own existence. All this we know, but think for a moment on the significance of their positions when we first see them. The Compasses lie within the confines of the Square and are dominated by it. Both of these things rest resolutely on an open page of the Volume of the Sacred Law. These 'Great Lights' and the lessons they teach are surely enough to see us safely through to that 'bright eternal day.'

‘Therefore when we build, let us think that we build forever. Let it not be for the present delight, nor for the present use alone. Let it be such work as our descendants will thank us for.’

-John Ruskin

As Freemasons, we know that we are not concerned with the building of any physical structure, yet we must be aware that we are trying to build something. What? Something less solid than a building, obviously, but hopefully of more value and, possibly, longer lasting: a better self and, thereby, a better world; a world free from the material madness and greed that grip it at this time. We work for the promotion of values that are beyond price and that are truly timeless and eternal. So if you are troubled, as we all are, by the pressures and disappointments of daily life, think for a moment of the Spiritual values that the Craft aims to inculcate within us. Think of the lasting benefits to your children and your children’s children of helping to make the world more sane, more peaceful, more full of brotherly love.

*‘What are you doing?’ a man asked three labourers beside a building under construction.
The first man replied, ‘Stone cuttin’.’
The second smiled. ‘Puttin’ in time until a better job comes along.’
The third man waited a moment and then said simply, ‘I’m building a cathedral.’”*

-Anon

It is true that, with all the important things in life, we get out of them what we put in. Freemasonry is no exception. Our most mundane chores can be exalted to the level of Spirituality if we approach them in the right frame of mind. In the same way, our highest aspirations can be brought low if we bring a grudging spirit to the attaining of them. We must all become involved in drudgery to survive in this modern world of ours, but never forget that, with the right attitude, a well-ironed sock or shirt is as fulfilling an accomplishment as a difficult piece of ritual well delivered or a good deed unselfishly done.

‘What do you mean by Masonry?’

‘We mean that great and universal science which includes almost every other...but we have more particularly studied that part which teaches us our duty to God and to our neighbour, and a knowledge of ourselves.’

-Ceremony of Exaltation

True self-knowledge has always been one of the highest aspirations of mankind. Through endless religions and philosophies we have tried to understand our universe and our part within it. Masonry is no different from other systems in this respect and points to the eternal truths that underlie all systems. In this extract there is a clear link between our duties to God and neighbour and with self-knowledge. This surely points to that most profound truth, the interconnection of all life. We cannot know ourselves if we neglect these duties because it is in their very performance that truth is revealed. Humility, reverence, love. These are our nature and, like a fragile plant, they will not grow in a desert of self-centred existence.

‘...in proportion to our capacities, we attain to a greater or lesser degree of perfection.’

-Second Lecture, Introductory Address

Among the many lessons that Freemasonry teaches are some that are very simple and universally applicable. The idea that we achieve results in proportion to the amount of effort we make is one such teaching. But Freemasonry is not about material gain, so while the same principle holds true of our jobs, our family life or our social standing, in Freemasonry it is elevated to the sphere of Spiritual endeavour.

‘As you sow, so shall you reap.’ It is a concept that has been with us for two thousand years. Use it to attain the highest degree of perfection possible.

'You agree to be a good Man and true, and strictly to obey the moral law.'

-Antient Charges

Initiation into Freemasonry is an acceptance of a great responsibility. By agreeing to be 'a good Man and true' we enter into an obligation, to ourselves no less than to God, to renounce selfishness and all the little dishonesties that it brings with it. We bind ourselves to act for the general good, making our every contact with others an expression of the truth that we are all one. This is the surest obedience to 'the moral law': to love God and love each other as we love ourselves.

‘Masonry, therefore, is not a competitor with religion though in the sphere of human conduct it may be hoped that its teaching will be complementary to that of religion.’

-Points of Procedure

There is no doubt that Masonry is a Spiritual pursuit. The fact that it has as its principal aim the betterment of humanity is proof enough of that assertion. Because it is a Spiritual pursuit, it is intensely religious and yet one of its beauties is that it adorns and enhances religion without usurping it. A good Mason will always be a good person and therefore, by extension, a good Christian, Jew, Hindu, Muslim, Sikh or whatever. We should allow our Masonic principles to adorn and enhance our religious beliefs so that all our actions are acceptable to ourselves, to others and to God.

*‘How should Freemasons meet?’
‘On the Level.’*

-Closing Ceremony

When we say that we meet ‘on the level’ we most usually think of our differing stations in life and it is true that Masonry allows us all to meet as equals, whatever our backgrounds. However, the concept of Masonic parity should also apply to our hearts and minds. As Masons we should always have our sights set on the highest levels of thought and behaviour and in this, too, we should be ‘on the level.’ All lives contain drudgery and it is often difficult to remain optimistic in the face of it but there is no doubt that to do so is the mark of a good Mason.

*'Live on old monuments of the past,
Our beacons through ages dark!
In primal majesty still you'll last,
Endeared by each Mason mark.'*

-Anon

In becoming Freemasons, we unknowingly attached ourselves to a huge weight of history. We became a part of that stream of ancient hope and endeavour which has crystallised into our modern Craft. No Mason can be unaware of the traditions of his Lodge, his Grand Lodge and of the institution as a whole and each Mason should try to feel a part of this heritage. Despite the many so-called scandals that have plagued it through the years, Freemasonry remains a system that advocates the highest to which human endeavour can attain. Only individual Freemasons can undermine this and so we should take care to nurture our Masonry with pride in its past and the determination to be the best of ambassadors for its future.

'There is a perennial nobleness, and even sacredness, in work...in idleness alone is there perpetual despair...'

-Thomas Carlyle

We should understand the word 'work' to mean more than just physical or even intellectual effort, and certainly more than the daily round of our employment, however worthwhile it may be. As human beings we are, with God, co-creators of the world and to strive always for its betterment is the true work of us all. In performing this work, we take our place alongside our Creator, fulfilling our role as tenders of His glorious garden. It is this which fills such work with sacredness. When we neglect our duties we fall away from God's plan for us and this will undoubtedly lead us into despair.

Let us determine to try to make the world a better place, to try to act in accordance with the Masonic precepts we espouse. As Masons we aim to construct a Temple fit for the Lord to dwell in; the building blocks of that temple are found in every human heart.

'That thing which I understand by real art is the expression by man of his pleasure in labour...A most kind gift is this of nature, since all men, nay, it seems all things, too, must labour.'

-William Morris

As human beings, we have within us an urge to create, an impulse to make sense of the world around us by the application of our labour in some sphere or another. The labour itself, as well as its fruit may be called art and it may take many forms. Anything good, well made by human effort, from a happy home to a successful business to a well-run Lodge can be seen as a work of art and it gives to its creator an inexpressible pleasure that is truly divine in origin. When we work mindfully and our work is such that it adds something to the common good, we become co-creators with God of the perfect world that must always remain our highest aim.

*‘What is the first duty of Entered Apprentice Freemasons in Lodge assembled?’
‘To see that the Lodge is properly tyled.’*

-Opening Ceremony

Tyling is about turning inwards, about shutting out the world with its everyday cares. It is a focussing of attention on our inner lives, a drawing in of breath; a moment's contemplation before action. See how the act of tiling and the calling of each officer in turn that immediately follows it is symbolic of how our attention dwells on the outside world. Then, by our own endeavour, it is drawn inward and upward until it comes to rest on, and act from, our highest Spiritual self.

*'You alone are your master
Who else?
Subdue yourself
To discover your master.'*

-Adapted from the Dhammpada

After tyling, after shutting out the distractions of the outside world, the lodge turns in on itself and, through ritual, the attention is guided up through the officers of the Lodge, representing their various functions, to the Master. He represents here our highest Spiritual self but even he has to turn for guidance to an authority that has gone beyond human knowledge, in the form of the Immediate Past Master. But there is a higher authority still, and the consciousness of the Lodge is raised again as the Chaplain invokes a blessing from the Almighty before the business of the meeting can proceed.

Our prayer must be that we continue to strive to raise our own consciousness and overcome the baser elements of our nature so that we may strip away the layers of illusion and discover our truest, deepest selves.

'Masons unite with the virtuous of every persuasion in the firm and pleasing bond of fraternal love;'
-Antient Charges

One of the greatest lessons Masonry teaches us lies in the admonishment to avoid discussion of things that could cause division amongst us. Instead of identifying each other and ourselves within the confines of title, job, political persuasion, religion, race or tribe, we are defined, not only as Masons and in ways peculiar to the Craft, but by a belief that things can be better, that humankind still has a long road to travel to fulfil its destiny and, most importantly, by the belief that we, as individuals, can make a difference. This longing to improve both ourselves and the world at large is the beginning of virtue and, while we preserve it as a Masonic virtue, we understand that it is not exclusively so.

'The level demonstrates that we are all sprung from the same stock, are partakers of the same nature, and sharers of the same hope;'

-Second Degree Ceremony

Freemasonry has always recognised that the widest principles of belonging unite us. Masons have firmly held to their belief that nothing less than a vision of all humankind as children of God is inclusive enough to reflect our true relationship with our Creator. The Working Tools of the Fellow-craft teach us important lessons of morality, equality and justness and uprightness of action, but here, as so often in our ritual, stress is put on the particular aspect that reminds us that the whole purpose of Freemasonry is to strive for a better world outside of the Lodge. The Level is a clear indication that, while we are united in our Lodges as Freemasons, beyond its confines we are, by our own assertion, members of an even wider family.

‘It should be understood by every Brother - and made clear at an early stage to every Candidate for Initiation - that membership of the Craft is not to be used as a means of promoting his personal or business advantage.’

-Points of Procedure

It is no coincidence that the thing the outside world most suspects us of is the very thing against which we must be most on our guard. It would be so easy to fall into the trap of treating our Masonic Brethren differently, of saving the best in ourselves for them. It is natural for us to feel a particular affinity with those who share our rites and there is no shame in rejoicing in the Brotherhood that Freemasonry brings us; but we must not lose sight of that most profound teaching of our Order: that all humankind is one family under God. Our treatment of every individual within the greater family should be such that it could not be bettered even when directed to the interests of a fellow Mason. We should not seek to raise our Brethren above humankind but should seek to treat all of humankind as our Brethren.

'FAITH...HOPE...CHARITY...These forces are within reach of all men; and an association of men, actuated by them, ought to exercise an immense power in the world. If Masonry does not, it it because she has ceased to possess them.'

-Albert Pike

At first this may seem like too harsh an indictment; but is it? The statement, 'Ye shall know them by their fruits,' is no less true now than it was two thousand years ago. We should dwell on these three virtues and ask ourselves how many of our daily actions are really founded on the rock they represent. It is in relation to this question that we may judge ourselves to be 'good' Masons and hence good people. The more we strive to live by the excellences which we claim motivate us, the more power for good Freemasonry will have in the world.

'May Freemasonry in every quarter of the globe become influential by diffusing the light of knowledge; aiding the strength of reason; dispensing the practice of virtue by lessening the aggregate of human misery and vice, by extending the bounties of charity and the blessings of peace to every deserving object under heaven.'

-Ceremony of Installation

Few of us are so placed that our actions can have any significant influence over public life, but all of us have it within our power to influence those with whom we come into daily contact. Be sure to put into daily practice those tenets you profess to admire within the Lodge. Let your life, by a simple and humble clinging to Masonic ideals, be a force for good. The light of knowledge, the strength of reason, the practice of virtue: these are the weapons that Freemasonry gives us, the armour with which it clothes us. Use them to live a life that does indeed extend the bounties of charity and the blessing of peace to the world.

If each Freemason lived such a life, spread across every quarter of the Globe as we are, what an influence that would be.

'You agree to avoid private piques and quarrels and to guard against intemperance and excess.'

-Antient Charges and Regulations

The intrusion of personal disagreements between its members is one of the greatest dangers to threaten Freemasonry and, indeed, all institutions where people come together for a common cause. This is the reason we are enjoined to avoid discussions which pertain to our personal religious or political beliefs. By focussing on the things that unite us, we willingly learn humility and to subdue our egos for the greater good. Remember that Freemasonry is essentially a guide on the path that leads from physicality to spirituality and, like others, teaches us to walk a Middle Way, eschewing all extremes, emotional as well as physical.

'Everyone who enters Freemasonry is, at the outset, strictly forbidden to countenance any act which may have a tendency to subvert the peace and good order of society;'

-Aims and Relationships of the Craft

Freemasonry is often accused of being reactionary because it tends to support the established order, but remember that we are exhorted thus very much on the assumption that a peaceful and well-ordered society exists around us. Nowhere are we enjoined to support, or keep silent about, tyranny of any kind. As Freemasons we are concerned with personal freedom and self-determination and so any society that allows its people to pursue these basic rights is worthy of our support. Freemasonry by its nature upholds the values of such a society and this is why it has always been the enemy of, and feared by, oppressors in every age.

*‘Name the three grand principles on which the Order is founded.’
‘Brotherly Love, Relief and Truth.’*

-Second Degree Ceremony

Not only does Brotherly Love ‘cement us’ together as a group, its very concept reminds us of our true relationship to God as our Creator and to humankind as brothers and sisters. The relief we offer is not just that found in our charitable donations, but also when we try to lighten the burden of human suffering by our own correct living. Our Truth is not the truth of any particular dogma or creed but that which underlies all dogmas and all creeds: God is our Creator and we are all God’s children. Let us try to live so that this truth, at least, is self-evident.

‘Brethren, this morally teaches us to set a guard at the entrance of our thoughts; place a watch at the door of our lips; and post a sentinel at the avenue of all our actions, thereby preserving a conscience void of offence before God and man.’

-Investiture of the Tyler

This injunction is often assumed to relate to the keeping of our so-called ‘secrets’ and perhaps on one level it does. On another, however, it is a repetition and a reminder of a much older instruction on how to live a pure life:

‘Do ye not yet understand, that whatsoever entereth in at the mouth goeth into the belly, and is cast out into the draught?’

‘But those things which proceed out of the mouth come forth from the heart; and they defile the man.’

‘For out of the heart proceed evil thoughts, murders, adulteries, fornications, thefts, false witness, blasphemies:

‘These are the things which defile a man: but to eat with unwashen hands defileth not a man.’

'Thought will not work, except in silence; neither will virtue work, except in secrecy.'

-Thomas Carlyle

Like its sister Mercy, Charity is something that affects both the giver and the receiver. Whether we give money to causes that touch our hearts, or whether we bring relief with a word or a smile, the act of doing good, of practising virtue, benefits the giver in ways that are hard to define. What we can understand, however, is a simple equation: we reap what we sow. A planting of virtuous action will result in a harvest of the spirit that will bring us ever nearer to our true selves and to God. But the seed must germinate in the darkness of secrecy. When we parade our virtue before the world, we expose the fragile shoots and eventually nothing grows. Let us determine to do our good deeds quietly, silently, so that the good we seek to do will come to fruition.

‘Learn something every day, and think often on what you have learned; by this you will gradually form your mind to embrace truth, from whatever quarter it may come.’

-William Frend

As the significance of the working tools of an Entered Apprentice are explained to a newly initiated Brother, it is stated that, while we take much of our symbolism and myth from the medieval craftsmen whose name we carry, we are not, of course, directly concerned with using the tools in their literal sense. At this point in the ritual we refer to ourselves as speculative Masons and this passing comment is of great significance. We are enjoined, elsewhere, to ‘make a daily advancement in Masonic knowledge’ and so it is clear that study and contemplation are vital parts of a Mason’s ‘work.’ If we are to speculate, on what should we speculate? The ritual helps us there, too. All of human life; the mysteries of Nature and Science; the liberal Arts and Sciences; even death itself is worthy of our contemplation. Our duty is to try to make sense of the world and our place in it. By constant study and mental effort we will, indeed, finally come to understand and embrace Truth.

'...as a Craftsman, you are expected to make the liberal Arts and Sciences your future study, that you may be the better enabled to discharge your duty as a Mason, and estimate the wonderful works of the Almighty Creator.'

-Second Degree Ceremony

By understanding the world, we are better able to understand ourselves and our place in it. As Masons we are called upon, not only to contemplate the beauty of the world, but also to make a real mental effort to comprehend the physical laws on which it is built. The physical is a manifestation of the Spiritual and insight into one leads to a clearer apprehension of the other. The liberal Arts and Sciences make sense of the world through language, thought and speech; through number and form; through sound and then beyond: to the movements of the Heavenly spheres themselves. Let us aspire to cultivate a true appreciation of the wonders of the universe and let us base that appreciation on genuine understanding.

‘Do not pray for easy lives; pray to be stronger men. Do not pray for tasks equal to your powers; pray for power equal to your tasks.

-Phillips Brooks

When we set our feet upon a path such as Freemasonry, we commit ourselves to a process of growth. It is not an easy path as it constantly requires a stretching, a breaking-out of old moulds to reshape ourselves in the light of the understanding we acquire. To want ‘easy lives’ or ‘tasks equal to our powers’ is to misunderstand the process of our Spiritual evolution and to turn our backs on the course we have chosen. Pain is often part of the process as we leave old selves, old belief systems and old crutches behind. As Freemasons we must accept responsibility for our own march towards the Godhead and so should welcome all difficulties and all challenges.

'All these charges you are to observe...cultivating brotherly love, the foundation and copestone, the cement and glory, of this antient fraternity...'

-Antient Charges

Any who doubt that Freemasonry is a Spiritual discipline would do well to think upon this beautiful summary of a Mason's duties. We learn and perform our rituals, we execute the more mundane business of the Lodge, we socialise, we practise Charity; we try to live good and ever better lives. All of these things are undoubtedly valuable and virtuous, worthy and worthwhile; but without the cultivation of love, they have nothing to set them apart from any other human pastime. Charity, the thing that Freemasonry sets such store by and the aspect of the organisation that is most often quoted to the public as our *raison d'être*, is love in action. Without it, giving is no more than an exercise in self-gratification or public relations. Masonic charities are important, as is Charity in the wider sense of the word, but we must understand that it is important to us because of our firm belief in the Brotherhood of all people in God. It is not Charity but the love that actuates it, that is our glory.

'...a time will most assuredly come when all distinctions save those of Piety and Virtue shall cease and Death, the grand leveller of all human greatness shall reduce us all to the same state.'

-Second Degree Ceremony

Whatever comes to us after death, Freemasons, being believers in God, tend to cling to the hope that we will continue to exist in a sphere of being that is more Spiritual than this earthly round and closer to God. We hold on to a faith that teaches us that goodness will be rewarded when our time comes. That may indeed be true, but, as Masons, we develop the firm conviction that goodness is its own reward in this life and, when Death comes for us, we think, not of our own reward, but of the world we leave behind. Is it a better place for our having sojourned here for a short while? Outward distinctions of rank, riches and influence will come to naught when Death strikes us, but will we leave behind us that greatest of legacies: a good name?

'He, of all men, should best understand that God seeth not as man seeth; for man looketh at the outward appearance, but God looketh to the heart. A mason is, therefore, particularly bound never to act against the dictates of his conscience.'

-Antient Charges

When we step on to a Spiritual path such as that offered to us by Freemasonry, we step beyond the value system of the outside world where rank, power and possessions hold so much sway. We embark upon a journey that we hope will raise us above the shallow and illusory delights of the mundane world and seek something deeper and more constant. While we live in the world, we understand our true purpose to be to rise above it and come at last to a point where everything of value that we wish for is to be found in things of the Spirit: to be able to offer brotherly love to all, relief of the suffering of our fellows and a firm grasp of truth. Let us try to learn to see beyond outward appearances and look, as God does, to the heart. With our attitudes and aspirations thus founded on true values, we will be better placed to exercise that freedom of conscience that Freemasonry allows us in all spheres of our lives, understanding always that freedom carries with it a great burden of responsibility.

‘As an Individual, let me recommend the practice of every domestic as well as public virtue.’

-First Degree Ceremony

Masonic Ritual often reminds us of the inherent differences between our public and private lives. So much of our daily existence is public - our jobs, our hobbies, our social circles - that it is an easy mistake to think that it is our actions in these spheres that are the most important. It is not that difficult to win acclaim in the eyes of those who are not closest to us. Charitable activities, outward charm and beneficence are enough to gain the world's approval. However, if we do not live to the same high standards in private - with our partners, our children, our close friends and relatives - who are we fooling? While the practice of public virtue may win for us a good name, it is only the practice of domestic virtue that will win for us the precious gifts of a clear conscience and an untroubled mind.

'Masonry recognizes the right of every man to worship God freely and according to the dictates of his own conscience and in his own way and according to the forms and ceremonies of his choice.'
-Arthur S. Tomkins

We are so often divided by the superficialities of our lives. Even the most profound aspects of our thoughts and our beliefs can so easily cause dissension. The endless wars that have been fought because of religion or ideology are proof enough of that. By bringing us together, united in our faith but at the same time recognising that each of us may understand and approach God in our own way, Freemasonry avoids the differences that divide one narrow creed or dogma from another and concentrates on the glorious truth that, whatever our race, our caste, our creed, we are all God's children.

*'Before God's footstool to confess
A poor soul knelt and bowed his head;
'I failed,' he cried. The master said,
'Thou didst thy best - that is success!''*

-Anon

Masons, being human, are generally less than perfect. Anybody who expects otherwise has a poor understanding of human nature and if perfection were a requirement for membership, there would be very few Masons indeed. Freemasonry itself, though, may be deemed to be perfect, in that it provides a vehicle for us to embark on a path that may eventually, through our own efforts, lead us to that perfection which we have come to understand is the ultimate goal of human endeavour. So, perfection is not required of us, but what is expected is a deep and heartfelt commitment to try to do our best in all spheres at all times. No one can ask us for more.

‘So far as I am acquainted with the principles and doctrines of Freemasonry, I conceive it to be founded in benevolence and be exercised only for the good of mankind...’

-George Washington

What a lovely thought! That Freemasonry is ‘founded in benevolence’ is indisputable. The endless theories put forward to explain the origins of our institution disagree on almost every point, but on one they are unanimous: Freemasonry was founded to bring benefit to the world. However, to believe that it is ‘exercised only for the good of mankind’ remains, at best, an idealistic dream. To make the dream come true should be the desire of every Mason who truly loves the Craft. To do this requires from each one of us a commitment to make our membership of it an influence in our lives that works for the benefit of all with whom we come into contact. We should reflect, each day, on the principles of our Order and put them into joyful practice, exercising them for the general good.

‘...Masonry, according to the general acceptation of the term is an Art founded on the principles of Geometry, and directed to the service and convenience of mankind.’

-First Lecture

That Freemasonry is directed to the ‘service and convenience of mankind’ is a truth that we should ever bear in mind as we move from the close confines of our Lodge meetings to our wider lives in the outside world. But that it is founded purely on the principles of Geometry is harder to grasp. We know that Freemasonry is a ‘peculiar system of morality, veiled in allegory, and illustrated by symbols,’ but to state that the Order is founded on principles of Geometry is a big leap of understanding. We need to spend time contemplating the truth of this statement. Geometrical structures obey strict laws and describe a perfection of shape, angle and form that cannot be altered. So it is with our lives and with the universe as a whole. It, too, is founded on unalterable laws and it, too, we have to assume, is perfect. Let us make it our constant duty to try to comprehend these laws and so tailor our daily lives as to live in accordance with them.

'...and honourable it must be acknowledged to be, as by a natural tendency it conduces to make those so who are obedient to its precepts.'

-First Degree Ceremony

Because it assumes a starting point of Faith, Masonry relies less on this concept than its counterpart, Religion. It is not so much concerned with imposing and supporting a belief system as with promoting the principles of sound actions. As such, it is less emotional than Religion and is often more a simple formula for good living. The precepts it expounds are endorsed by all religions and they are so embedded in Masonic ritual and symbolism that it is impossible to follow them and not become a better person. As we renew our determination to live by the Masonic 'line and rule' we should do so in the awareness that, as we are deemed honourable by our association with Freemasonry, so the Craft itself is deemed honourable only through our actions.

'Grandeur of character lies wholly in the force of soul, in the force of thought, moral principles, and love, and this may be found in the humblest conditions of life.'

-William Ellery Channing

As Freemasons we value the concept of grandeur. It is symbolised most forcefully in our rituals through our vision of that grand Temple, God's house, the home of our highest aspirations. We see grandeur not as an outward, ostentatious display of wealth, rank or privilege, but as an inner strength, an inner virtue that shines out from the depths of a person's soul. To achieve this grandeur of character we must cultivate the highest standards of conduct, be true to the dictates of our conscience and, as ever, try to put into constant practice our belief in the principle of brotherly love. This is the way of virtue and, thus, of inner grandeur.

'...as in the previous degree you made yourself acquainted with the principles of moral truth, you are now permitted to extend your researches into the hidden mysteries of nature and science.'

-Second Degree Lecture

If the liberal Arts and Sciences are the foundations of knowledge in the second degree, then it is the twin mysteries of Divine Creation and human understanding that form the bedrock on which they stand. Knowledge is power and it is not for nothing that we are led to its portals along the path of morality and virtue. Masonry calls itself a progressive science and recognises that we must develop our character before we can be entrusted with that which has the power to awaken our souls. We must be perfect vessels for the sacred balm our system offers, perfect ashlar in the building of the universal Temple.

'To steer the bark of this life over the rough seas of passion, without quitting the helm of rectitude is the highest degree of perfection to which human nature is capable of attaining.'

-Second Degree Ceremony

There is no doubt that one of the highest tasks we can aim for as human beings is the overcoming of our baser passions, our lower selves. All of our religions and all our history teach us that we are engaged on a slow upward path from physicality to Spirituality. We often go wrong, thinking that we should try to subdue our passions completely, but this would be to deny that we have a lower self at all. We must learn to control our passions, not suppress them, and to do that we need something to hold on to, to give us strength: our philosophies and our religions. For those of us who have chosen Freemasonry as our boat over these 'rough seas,' the moral framework which we build around the symbolism of the Craft must be strong enough to survive all the raging storms of this life. For that, we must build it with care.

*'There is so much good in the worst of us,
And so much bad in the best of us,
That it ill behoves any of us
To find fault with the rest of us.'*

-Anon

One of the finest and, paradoxically, one of the most practical aspects of Freemasonry is that it teaches us only to be the very best we can, not try to be what we cannot. Like Jacob's ladder, Freemasonry is planted firmly on the ground in our humanity but reaches to the heavens in our higher selves. While having the highest of ideals, it recognises all human weakness, thereby giving us realistic expectations and aspirations. Being a good Freemason therefore means that we must acknowledge our own weaknesses and strengths and, through them, learn to deal more kindly, more compassionately, with the faults of others.

'...while some must rule and teach others, of necessity, must learn to submit and obey; humility in each is an essential virtue.'

-Installation Ceremony

Although the world at large is increasingly shying away from hierarchical structures for fear that they might somehow undermine our essential equality, we as Freemasons understand that, while inequalities exist between people in many ways, our basic worth as children of God is unalterable. From the basis of that understanding, we also recognise that all Initiatory paths are hierarchical in structure and Freemasonry is no different.

The first important thing to acknowledge is that our system advocates advancement through merit and that merit is gained through effort. The second is that Freemasonry understands that there is always more to learn. Whether you are a new initiate or a Past Master, further study will bring its rewards. A constant attitude of receptiveness is what opens us - heart and mind - to new and deeper truths and it is this grateful receptivity that we call humility.

'They remind us that even the qualities of uprightness of conduct, humanity of disposition, and energy of purpose may deaden and kill the spiritual principle within us if applied to no greater use than merely selfish or ambitious ends.'

-Third Degree Ceremony

It seems to be part of the human lot that we so easily cloak ourselves in self-righteousness, where our own perceived virtue leads us to believe we are in a position to judge others. We step out onto the path of self-improvement motivated by high ideals: the betterment not only of ourselves, but of all humanity. However, if we do not take care, the elevated nature of our purpose inflates our self-importance and leads us into justifying actions that undermine the very advancement we are trying to demonstrate.

We must constantly measure our actions and our thoughts against the principles we profess and be sure that humility does not become arrogance and all our efforts come to naught.

'...you will also notice that a Brother's hands reach beyond his immediate neighbour and this is to show you that Freemasonry should go beyond helping a Brother and should reach out into the world to help all of mankind.'

-Entered Apprentice Chain

We must never lose sight of the fact that Freemasonry has practical applications in our daily lives. It is so easy to leave our Masonic ideals untouched from one month to the next, locked in a briefcase with our regalia, but when we do this we render the whole system worthless. There is no benefit to anyone if we only think about the Craft when we attend our Lodges. The dictates and principles of our Order must inform our actions every day if they are to have any meaning at all. It is this that we must strive to achieve, as it is only through this that Freemasonry will find its proper place as a force for good in the world.

*'In this world
Hate has never dispelled hate.
Only love can dispel hate.
This is the law,
Ancient, yet always new.'*

-Adapted from The Dhammapada

This teaching from the East has its own resonance in Western traditions:
'...resist not evil: but whosoever shall smite thee on thy right cheek, turn to him the other also.'

What we need to understand here is the immutability of this statement, this 'law.' Hate does nothing but feed on itself and grow ever bigger and more destructive. Love is the humbling force that starves hatred and withers it on the spot. This is one of the greatest teachings of all religions and one of the reasons that Freemasonry aims to cultivate in our hearts a love of all humanity. By filling our lives with love - a detached, unselfish love - we touch other lives, multiplying and spreading that love behind and around us like the wake of a ship or the ripples of a fish, disturbing the silent surface of a tranquil lake.

*'The heights by great men reached and kept
Were not attained by sudden flight,
But they, while their companions slept
Were toiling upward in the night.'*

-Henry Wadsworth Longfellow

It is not easy, this consciously stepping on to a path of self-knowledge. As soon as we rise above the valley that is the common human condition, we see with a new perspective and, attaining the heights, we can never again immerse ourselves in much of the pettiness of life without feeling ill at ease. Having once set a loftier course for ourselves, we are doomed to see the futilities of our lives for what they are. We can never be satisfied with whatever is in us that does not strive for perfection and so, although we live in the world, we are slightly apart from it and our appreciation of its beauty is forever tinged with the poignancy of its - and our own - transience.

*'Exchanging fragmentary news or prophecies of crop
Until they reach the Tyler's room and current topics drop.
To turn their thoughts to nobler themes they cherish and adore,
And which were heard in meeting night up over Simkin's store.'*

-Lawrence N. Greenleaf

One of the great joys of our Lodge meetings, be they weekly, monthly or quarter-yearly, is that they offer a few hours respite from the cares of the world. When we pass from the Tyler's room into the Temple itself, we should leave all our daily concerns outside and indeed turn our 'thoughts to nobler themes.' This turning inward and upward of consciousness is the same escape found by religious people in their fervent prayer and by mystics in their meditation. It is not something to feel uncomfortable or embarrassed about but is something we should embrace thankfully, using the time to refresh our Spirits so that when we re-enter the world we are stronger, better people.

'By such exemplary conduct you will convince the world that merit has been your title to our privileges, and that on you our favours have not been undeservedly bestowed.'

-Third Degree Charge

After the drama and emotion of a degree ceremony, a serious charge is once more laid upon us. Amongst other things, we are reminded that each of us, as an individual, carries the weight of Freemasonry on our shoulders. The world will judge the whole by its parts and it is up to us, who are the parts that make up the whole that is Freemasonry, to ensure that the reputation of the Order is preserved.

There is no doubt that the world at large has had a generally negative image of Freemasonry and if we are to continue to change that, it will be by proving its falsehood by our behaviour. We should always act in such a manner that our actions are a positive reinforcement of Freemasonry's tenets. After all, have we not all made the decision that it is those tenets which will regulate our words and deeds?

'...a spirit of emulation prevails, and each vies as to who shall excel in promulgating the valuable principles of the institution.'

-Second Degree Lecture

Those of us who work the Emulation Rite would do well to ponder the meaning of the word thought important enough to give its name to the whole system. Those who do not can only admire the wisdom of the men who lit the beacon blaze shining out in that name.

Is this not one of the great joys of our workings? The joy of excellence; the joy of exalted rivalry as we first emulate and then aim to be worthy of emulation ourselves; to give of our best to the lofty ideals of the institution and to be perfect vehicles for the plan laid out in its rituals.

'...thereby enabling you to exercise those talents wherewith God has blessed you as well to His Glory as to the welfare of your fellow creatures.'

-First Degree Ceremony

Masonry is something that should touch and influence our deepest selves. Being established in God, it is the foundation of a house 'built upon a rock.' Whatever is done to the house above, the foundations are unchanged. We should learn to think of the Craft as the substructure of a temple which is our life. By adopting the symbols of Masonry as our base and our design, we can walk the chequered path of this existence secure in the knowledge that what we build will not fall because it is founded in Truth. With this thought in mind, try always to be guided by the ideals that, in your last Lodge meeting, you professed to admire.

'My real faith then is in a dream that, in spite of daily headlines prophesying man's destruction, we can build a better world, a world of peace and human brotherhood. Yes, even in our lifetime...In my small way I want to have a share in making it come about.'

-Julien Bryan

As Freemasons, this is a faith and a dream to which we should all subscribe. Why else would we be Masons? Why else would we spend so much of our time working to improve ourselves and each other? The ideals of brotherhood and, by a natural extension, peace, are close to our hearts and at the core of our rituals. An important point here is that we do all have a part to play in making this dream a reality, even if it is a small part. Very few of us move in circles where our actions and decisions will have a global impact, but all of us are the centre of a circle, however seemingly insignificant, from which our actions will influence those around us. As Masons we must be sure that all we do takes our immediate circle closer to the fulfilment of our dream.

'Truth never yet fell dead in the streets; it has such affinity with the soul of man, the seed however broadcast will catch somewhere and produce its hundredfold.'

-Theodore Parker

Truth is like a butterfly: vibrant and beautiful until it is captured and pinned down. Truth is not an exclusive commodity and cannot be contained in any one creed. Freemasonry recognises this and has as one of its aims the enrichment of our religious lives, whatever our faith. Truth informs our ritual and guides our principles but nowhere do we find a suggestion that we are sole possessors of 'The Truth.' As the sound of a church bell may be heard by all and stir the hearts of many, worshippers or not, so Truth will make itself known to all who seek it, conforming to the outer form of their faith. And how do we recognise this Truth that cannot be encompassed? By its atmosphere, its spirit, its resonance within our deepest selves.

‘... in giving him a virtuous and liberal education, his mind becomes cultivated and he is thereby rendered a fit member of civilised society.’

-First Degree Ceremony

Many of us who have arrived at the portals of Freemasonry have been attracted to the vision of a humanity ennobled by its profound teachings of morality, truth and love. We have learned to love its ritual and its history and have gained much from our association with it. But we have not arrived here as a result of our own innate wisdom and virtue. No, the very fact that we find this vision attractive is a direct result of the education we received which taught us to prize these ideals above material rank and fortune. We should be forever grateful to our parents or guardians, our teachers and to society at large for that education and we should use our influence and strive always to ensure that such an education - both virtuous and liberal - is available to all the world's children.

'Let us discard all this quibbling about this man and the other man, this race and that race and the other race, being inferior...Let us discard all these things, and unite as one people throughout this land, until we shall once more stand up declaring that all men are created equal.'

-Abraham Lincoln

Although we eschew the discussion of politics at our meetings, we cannot fail to be aware of the many wrongs in the world. Neither are we expected to avoid difficult issues because they may seem 'political'. As Masons we are determined to right wrongs in any lawful way available to us but we should do so by rising higher and finding remedies that are founded on the Spiritual principles that actuate us. Our basic premise that all of us are God's children is one that can allow for no wrong to go unchallenged and so, on social issues we enter, of necessity, the political arena. Try to be sure that even in this sphere, your actions are guided by Masonic principles and avoid everything that causes division and strife in the world.

'...admonishing us to be careful to perform every operation in its proper season, that we lose not the fruits of our labour.'

-Ceremony of Exaltation.

All of life may be viewed as a series of causes and effects. From the primordial impulse that created the physical universe to the smallest doings of our daily lives, there springs an endless chain of action and reaction. When we set out on the path of Freemasonry, we are, often unknowingly, taking the first step towards controlling that chain. We begin to make conscious use of the forces that govern our lives and we behave in such a way, understanding what the effect will be. We begin to harness that universal urge towards perfection that is instilled in all of us. But once started, we must continue. To not continue is to give up what progress we have made and so to lose the fruits of our labours. Remembering that we labour for the good of humankind, we must commit to bear the responsibility bravely and strive always to move forward.

'Pendant to the four corners of the Lodge are four tassels, which represent the four cardinal virtues- namely, Temperance, Prudence, Fortitude and Justice.'

-First Degree Ceremony

During the second degree ceremony, the candidate is taught that a Fellow-craft Freemason should *'...observe a due medium between avarice and profusion [and] hold the scales of Justice with an equal poise...'* This reminds us that in all things, a good Mason is encouraged to tread a 'middle way', avoiding extreme in all things. As Masons we are very much part of society; even though we try to lift ourselves above its pettiness and materialism, the joys and successes of the world are ours and so too are its failings and its sorrows. We need to learn to be moderate in all we do; to do what is needful or appropriate, but not to lose ourselves in any vice or addiction - good or bad - that tends to lead us away from our chosen path. This moderation in thought, word and deed, is Temperance in its widest sense.

'Truth's tough. It will not break, like a bubble, at a touch; you may kick it about all day, like a football, and it will be round and full at evening.'

-Oliver Wendell Holmes

There is no doubt that truth endures. Falsehood, too, has strength and existence but, in time, it is exposed for what it is and it falls away. It is not robust and cannot stand the probing and testing of daily life. Truth, on the other hand, in all its various guises, can stand such testing. By its very nature it is strong because it reflects reality, the way things actually are.

Much of Freemasonry might be seen as quaintly old-fashioned by the outside world but to many of us that is part of its charm. Meanwhile the important lessons it teaches continue to have real force and import for us and this, if any were needed, is proof enough that it contains much that is real and true.

Don't be afraid to put Freemasonry to the test. Use the lessons it teaches, practise the principles it expounds; be proud of this vehicle that can do so much to improve the lot of humankind. It can stand it. It is tough because its basic message is a true one. You can rely on it.

'...to seek the solace of your own distress by extending relief and consolation to your fellow creatures in the hour of their affliction.'

-Third Degree Ceremony

The practice of Charity, and the development of empathy that characterises it, is an exercise that leads to a fuller understanding of our relationship to each other. When we learn that the measure of our own happiness lies in our response to the suffering of our fellows, we will have learned the great truth that we are all a part of the same Life. Like the silky threads of a spider's web, the strands of life connect us in a vast, unimaginable unity, where the lightest touch on any part sets up vibrations of consequence in all the others. When we help others, we are also helping ourselves, and many more beyond the immediate circle of our aid. Understand the truth of this thought and be sure that all of your giving, all of your 'extending relief and consolation' comes from your heart before anything comes from your pocket.

*'Although our past achievements we with conscious pride review,
As long as there's Rough Ashlars there is work for us to do.
We still must shape the Living Stone with instrument of love,
For that eternal Mansion in the Paradise above.
Toil as we've toiled in ages past, to carry out the plan-
'Tis this: The Fatherhood of God, the Brotherhood of Man.'*

-Lawrence N. Greenleaf

Those who love to denigrate Freemasonry for being what they consider to be no more than an exclusive social club, have clearly not studied the teachings of the Order. The ideals of Freemasonry are the highest to which humankind can aspire: the betterment of all life and the Spiritualisation of humanity. It does not suit all people and nor does it need to. However, it does need to be recognised as a real force for good in this increasingly materialistic and confused modern world. For this to happen though, each individual Freemason must hold to these aspirations and so live a life that will reflect the high ideals of the Craft. Let us determine to do so.

‘It cannot be too strongly asserted that Masonry is neither a religion nor a substitute for religion.’

-Points of Procedure

If religion is defined as a belief in a superhuman or controlling power, particularly a personal God, then it must be acknowledged that there is much that is religious in Freemasonry. But if religion is defined as a particular system of faith and worship, then Freemasonry can be seen as something rather different. In their wisdom, the founders of our Art recognised that religion is tied up with culture and self-identity, not only with belief. Religion not only provides a framework within which to see the world, but it provides ceremony and ritual to mark the milestones in our lives: birth, coming of age, marriage and death. Freemasonry does not provide those things, nor does it invoke a peculiarly Masonic deity. What it does is, taking faith in God as a starting point, provide a framework and a set of symbols over which one may lay one's religious life in order that it may be more clearly seen and more readily lived. Freemasonry can never be a substitute for religion, but it will always be an institution that will enhance and protect all religions that strive, as it does, for the common good.

‘Our Lodges are supported by three great pillars. They are Wisdom, Strength and Beauty. Wisdom to contrive, Strength to support, and Beauty to adorn the inward man.’

-First Degree Ceremony

The construction of that great Temple in Jerusalem is a great symbol and guide for us in our lives. It is a metaphor for the life we attempt to build for ourselves founded on the high moral principles of the Order. When we build and whatever we build - whether it be in word, thought or deed - we should check that our edifice is also supported by these three pillars.

We must ask ourselves, ‘Is this wise? Is it built on firm foundations and therefore strong? And will it add something to the beauty and harmony of the universe?’ Only if the answer to these questions is an unequivocal, ‘Yes,’ should we go ahead and lay the cornerstone.

‘...as a Craftsman, you are expected to make the liberal arts and sciences your future study that you may the better be enabled to discharge your duties as a Mason, and estimate the wonderful works of the Almighty.’

-Second Degree Lecture

The seven liberal arts and sciences constitute the traditional foundations of our educational systems. The ancient concept of ‘Mens sana in corpore sano’ provided for the ‘healthy mind’ through a well-structured curriculum aimed at developing balance and tranquillity as well as the cultivation of the virtues of Faith, Hope and Charity. Grammar, rhetoric and logic teach us how to think, how to structure our thought and how to express it. Arithmetic and geometry demonstrate in line and number the great harmony of the universe which is manifested audibly through music and visibly, in the Heavens, through the science of astronomy.

Learning does not end with our schooldays and Freemasonry is a system designed to continue our education, refining and polishing us until we are ‘rendered fit for the intended structure,’ perfect ashlar for the building of that ‘ethereal mansion, not made with hands, eternal in the heavens.’

*'Where were you first prepared to be made a Mason?
'In my Heart.'*

-Second Degree Ceremony

There is much in our ceremonies that highlights the importance of a heartfelt appreciation of our Art. In the Scottish ritual the candidate has the meaning and symbolism of his preparation explained to him. It is stated that the purpose of the hoodwink is, among other things, *'...that your heart might conceive before your eyes beheld the beauties of Freemasonry.'*

It is in this preconceived love of the ideals and lofty vision of the Craft that the first seeds of our life in the Order are sown.

'That Masons are builders can be seen by the name... By teaching men the doctrines of temperance, fortitude, prudence and justice, together with the many lessons drawn from, and daily application to the activities of life, deep foundations are laid upon which the loftiest character must stand.'

-Owen Scott

It is not just the fact that we borrow much of our symbolism from operative stonemasons that is significant here, it is the fact that we borrow them specifically from the builders of God's house, that great Temple in Jerusalem. The craftsmen we so profess to admire, personified for us in the figures of the Kings, Solomon of Israel and Hiram of Tyre and of the master-builder, Hiram Abiff, worked to create a structure of such grandeur and beauty that it would be fit to house the Spirit and Presence of God. If we are to match their aspiration, we must aim to build, with our lives, a structure that is also fit for God's habitation.

*'Not what we give, but what we share,
For the gift without the giver is bare:
Who gives himself with alms feeds three,
Himself, his hungry neighbour, and Me.'*

-James Russel Lowell

Charity without feeling is unworthy of the name. When we give, we should do so from a spontaneous sympathy born of fellow-feeling and brotherly concern. If we give alms only to salve our conscience, then we fail to understand the true nature of ourselves and our relationship with our Creator. All life is One and is an expression of God. If we do not recognise our brother, we deny our Creator and to do that is to reduce ourselves to the level of beasts.

‘I pray you with all earnestness to prove and to know within your hearts that all things lovely and righteous are possible for those who believe in their possibility, and who determine that for their part they will make each day’s work contribute to them.’

-John Ruskin

Within each human being, at our very core, resides the soul that animates us. It is, at the same time, our deepest self and a spark of the Divine. The cares and trials of this life conspire to bury that spark ever deeper within us, to extinguish its flame, to bring us to a point where we believe that the material world around us is all there is. But, like water, that divine spark seeks its own level and so it is that all human beings have something within themselves that aspires to great heights, that has an impulse to create beauty, to believe in and seek the ideal, to love that Light from which our innermost selves spring. As a result, the world, for all its woes, is full of individuals and organisations striving for the common good. We have embraced Freemasonry and we lift ourselves towards the light by our measured steps on Jacob’s ladder. Remember that the most important rungs are Faith, Hope and Charity. Tread them joyfully, knowing that in doing so, you fulfil your true destiny.

'In all cases of difficulty and danger, in whom do you put your trust? '
'In God.'

-First Degree Ceremony

This answer, so glibly put into our mouths by our conductor, even before we are truly made Masons, is one worthy of deep reflection for on it rests the whole superstructure of Masonic thought. As human beings, and particularly as Masons, we try always to do the best we can. We try to tailor our lives to conform to the plans of the Great Architect and so be free of the troubles that are our lot. But, as humans, we constantly fall away from our chosen path and succumb to the pitfalls that life puts in our way. When this happens, when we are faced by a task or a temptation that seems too big or strong for us to handle, to whom should we turn? To God, of course, the source of all our faith:

'I will love thee, O Lord my strength.

'The Lord is my rock, and my fortress, and my deliverer;

my God, my strength in whom I will trust;

my buckler, and the horn of my salvation, and my high tower.'

‘...Happy to meet, sorry to part, happy to meet again.’

-Parting Toast at the Festive Board

It is hard to describe to someone who has not experienced it, the sense of comradeship that is created at our meetings. We come together from so many different walks of life, so many social groups, such a wide span of ages, of races and religions that, in any other sphere, it would be hard to see what could unite us. But, through our association with Freemasonry, we really do meet ‘on the Level’ and are united by our desire to make ourselves better people and the world a better place. If we allow it, our meetings will raise us to a higher plane where we act from the deepest levels of human existence and that is a place where all external differences become as naught. How lucky we are to be able to experience this. How true it is that we are happy to meet in such circumstances, sorry to part at the end of the evening and, even in the act of parting, we look forward to the next time we will join together to work for the benefit of humanity in the company of like-minded Brethren.

‘All preferment among masons is grounded upon real worth and personal merit only;’

-Antient Charges

We are told time and again in our ritual that Masonry is a ‘progressive science’ and it is true that our system is so designed as to reveal to us aspects of truth as we develop our minds to receive it. Also, we progress through the various offices in the Lodge, usually in a well-defined order. Sometimes it seems that this progress is based purely on the question of who is next in line and little account appears to be taken of who most deserves preferment. From the outside, then, it could appear that ‘personal merit’ has little to do with progress but in fact the system works well because, once again, it assumes that all members of the Lodge are trying their hardest and are giving of their best. This genuine effort, for us, is proof enough of ‘worth and personal merit’ and is the only qualification necessary to proceed. Excellence is not required but a heartfelt and steadfast desire to keep trying, to keep improving, as human beings and as Masons, is.

'As Masons we should so act on the square as to enable us to part on the level with all mankind.'

-First Lecture

By square conduct, we, as Masons, understand that our actions should be marked by honesty and integrity. We are often reminded that these standards of behaviour are not to be limited to our Lodge meetings but should mark us out as 'good and true' to all the world. Although our meetings can act as an inspiration to us to strive always to maintain the highest standards of behaviour in regard to our dealings with all people, if that high-mindedness does not stay with us beyond the confines of the Lodge, it is of little value.

Our job as Masons is not to behave perfectly in Lodge and use that as a sop to our conscience when we fail to maintain those standards outside it, it is to try to carry that perfection into our daily lives and to learn to treat all of humankind as Brethren. And when we do depart from this world, as we all must, let the accolade, 'He was a good Mason,' be secondary to the greater acknowledgement of merit: 'He was a good man.'

‘Those three things did then, have since, and I trust ever will render the groundwork of Freemasonry Holy.’

-First Degree Ceremony

The First Degree Tracing Board contains a huge amount of information for the new initiate. It begins with an explanation of the symbolism of the outer form of the Lodge and it seeks to explain how it may be considered a Temple. It asks the initiate to consider that there are three things that lend our lodges holiness. They are compliance with the will of God, demonstrated by the willingness of Abraham to sacrifice his son; prayer, particularly for others, exemplified by the prayers of King David on his people's behalf; and thanksgiving like that shown by King Solomon and his household at the completion of the great Temple in Jerusalem.

Remembering this, we teach the initiate that when we enter our Lodges, we should try to put aside mundane matters and walk in humility in God's presence, for we stand on Holy ground.

'...and from the foundation laid this evening may you raise a superstructure perfect in its parts, and honourable to the builder.'

-First Degree Ceremony

Becoming a Freemason is no great accomplishment. A phone call to the local Masonic centre could do it; meet a few people, pay your dues, confirm your belief in a Supreme Being, promise to attend meetings regularly...and that's about it. A whole world of social opportunities opens up to you; the regular comradeship of your fellow Lodge members; even travel to other parts of the country or, indeed, other countries will afford opportunities for Brotherly visits. The process is simple, the benefits are obvious: in itself, it is no great accomplishment. But to be a good Freemason, that is something more. A good Freemason, while enjoying and valuing the society that Masonry brings, knows that there is more to the Craft than that. We have to understand that becoming a Freemason is not the end of a journey but the beginning of one. Being a Mason does not automatically make us good people. That requires our own effort. The philosophical basis of Freemasonry and the discipline of its rituals provide us with the firmest of foundations but the building of the perfect superstructure is up to us.

'You agree to promote the general good of Society, to cultivate the Social Virtues, and to propagate the knowledge of the Mystic Art as far as your influence and ability can extend.'

-Antient Charges

Perhaps one of the greatest difficulties that Freemasonry faces today is the question of how to present itself to the world. We are enjoined here to spread the knowledge of 'the Mystic Art' as widely as we can, and yet we undertake a most solemn obligation never to 'wilfully reveal any...of the secrets or mysteries of Freemasonry...' There appears to be a clear conflict between the two duties outlined here and we need to consider the question in greater depth. What is it that we are to spread and what does honour demand that we never reveal?

The true lessons of Freemasonry, as of all Spiritual teachings, are open to all. The key message of universal brotherhood under One God can, and should, be proclaimed by us, even if it is without words, in all we do and in all our dealings with others. What we have promised to keep secret are the things peculiar to Freemasonry that are designed, not to exclude outsiders, but as a gift and a privilege to those who choose to commit themselves to this particular path.

‘The distinguishing characteristics of a good Freemason are Virtue, Honour and Mercy, and may they ever be found in a Freemason’s heart.’

-First Degree Ceremony

There is a certain irony in that we, as Masons, are to be distinguished by three things that are not always seen by our wider materialistic society as being of any value at all. The three excellences of character mentioned here are quiet ones, ones that grow and bear fruit in humility and strength of character. It is significant that they are to be looked for in a good Mason’s heart, for they are inner, Spiritual virtues. While many in the outside world might value wealth, power and fame as an end in themselves, we prefer to strive for a different kind of riches and we know that a simple life, well lived, is the ‘highest to which human nature can attain.’

*'May our work, begun in Thee,
Ever blest with order be,
And may we, when labours cease,
Part in harmony and peace.'*

-Opening Hymn

The process of opening the Lodge is an important one. So much of the early part of the ritual of any degree is designed purely to focus our minds and hearts on the main work of the ceremony that is to come. Gradually our attention is drawn away from the outer world and brought to rest on the teachings and symbolism to be found within the Lodge. The singing of an opening hymn is a part of this process and it has the added virtue of forcing us to unite in a song of praise and, literally, fill the very air with vibrations of harmony and peace.

'What is Freemasonry?'

'A peculiar system of morality, veiled in allegory and illustrated by symbol.'

-Second Degree Ceremony

When asked by non-Masons to explain what Masonry is, we often struggle to find the right words. We tend to answer in terms of what Freemasonry does in the outer world, particularly in terms of the amount of charity it does. It is as if we can only understand it ourselves and justify it to others in a way that is acceptable and concrete and so we end up by presenting ourselves purely as a charitable institution. This is not untrue: we do a great deal of good in the world, but it is not what we are. Charity is the logical outcome of a system that stresses the correct relationship between humanity and God. But being a charitable organisation is not enough to explain why we have 'strange' and private rituals. We need to be clearer in our understanding of what we are and present that understanding in a clearer light to society at large. We are private and it is true that we do have secrets, but that is our right and our privilege. That we work for the benefit of humankind is neither private nor secret. Let us be proud of what we are and let the truth of the fact that Freemasonry teaches morality above all else shine out from us all.

‘To all poor and distressed Masons, where’er they may be.’

-The Tyler’s Toast

The Tyler’s toast is the last ritual act of the evening. After the formality of the ceremony within the Lodge and the structured but less formal gathering of the festive board, where we often enjoy good food and fine wine, we are called upon to remember our less fortunate Brethren. This moving toast reminds us that even within the ranks of Freemasonry there are those who suffer or who are adrift and lost on the stormy seas of life and we pray for an end to their wanderings and their pain. It means that, before we leave the comradeship of our fellows to return to our daily lives, our attention is once more drawn to the fact that Freemasonry widens our sphere of interest and influence enormously. There are Freemasons and, therefore, people generally, across the whole of the globe, living in conditions that we would consider beneath human dignity. Our prayer for ‘poor and distressed Masons’ should not only cause us to consider the suffering of our Brothers, but also that of our wider human family. Let us be thankful for what we have in comparison, but let us also determine to do what we can to work for a better, fairer world.

‘There is no truth more thoroughly established, than that there exists in the economy and course of nature an indissoluble union between virtue and happiness, between duty and advantage, between the genuine maxims of an honest and magnanimous policy, and the solid rewards of public prosperity and felicity.’

-George Washington

Much of what we are and what we do as Masons involves the progress of the individual along the path of life. We strive to ensure that the path we take and along which we try to guide our Brothers is one that will, through correctly applied effort, lead to virtue. We understand the connection between virtue and happiness and that we will all reap what we have sown. What we sometimes forget is the wider picture, the benefit to society at large that our attempts to improve ourselves will bring. Like yeast in dough, the benevolent actions of individuals are what results in ‘public prosperity.’ Let us not lose sight of this great truth; when the condition and direction of the world gets us down, let us not become disheartened. What we do and how we behave as individuals does matter.

'A younger brother shall be instructed in working...for increasing and continuing of brotherly love.'
-Antient Charges

When we come to Freemasonry, we are initiated into its customs and mysteries not only through the formula of its ritual, but by the words and attitudes of our new-made Brethren. Just as members of a family may treat each other with easy familiarity when alone, but demonstrate their strength and solidarity when with others, so should we take care to show off our Craft in its best and most dignified light to a new-comer when, with more experienced Brethren, we might be more carefree in our approach. To enjoy the company of our Brethren in Lodge and at the festive board is important, but more important is to instil in a new candidate a proper reverence and respect for the rituals and customs of the Order. Masonic ritual is fine, well-crafted and noble but without people to use and transmit it carefully and respectfully, it is just so many words.

Let us aim to transmit the outer form and inner spirit of Freemasonry to our 'younger' Brethren in such a way that they will easily and quickly learn to love our mystic Art.

'...ever remembering the intention, which is the acquisition of love, wisdom and understanding...'

-Ceremony of Exaltation

For all the pleasure we derive from our association with Freemasonry, for all the festive boards and social gatherings, even those with a charitable purpose, we must remember that we are engaged in a Spiritual pursuit and our great and final aim is to move humankind closer to God. Social and charitable activities and the enjoyment of the companionship of our Brethren are not necessarily of less value than the business within the Lodge, but we need to differentiate between what is cause and what is effect. Masonic ritual and philosophy lie at the core of what we do; it is this that brings us together as companions with shared experience and it is this that actuates us to give to those less fortunate than ourselves.

So let us enjoy our gatherings, our festive boards, our charitable galas and let us continue to bring material benefit to those in need. But let us not lose sight of that mountain peak of love, wisdom and understanding which is our highest aspiration and the source of true Brotherhood.

‘We deem the lowest service in the work of the Lord to be to us an honour...’

-Ceremony of Exaltation

The real test of Brotherhood does not lie in fine words or in lofty philosophy; it is not brought to light in high ideals or a good heart alone. All these things might inspire the belief in universal Brotherhood and help it to actuate and inform a person’s approach to life, but it is only in the living of that life that these principles can be truly seen.

For the concept of brotherhood to mean anything, it must be with all humankind and this means with the lowest as well as the highest in society. Understanding our true relationship with our Creator, Masons must strive to serve all people without distinction, without fear of reprisal or hope of reward other than that which comes from knowing that we are doing ‘the work of the Lord.’

‘There is no secret with regard to any of the basic principles of Freemasonry...’

-Aims and Relationships of the Craft

It is a great shame that so many in the world look upon Freemasonry with mistrust. Of course, it is often the case that where a group of people keep secrets, there will be anger, resentment and suspicion; but we need also to ask ourselves if we have not played a part in allowing this negative image to go unchallenged. Pointing out that we do much for charity is seen as something of a sop because it simply does not explain why secrecy and privacy are so prized by us. We are confused about what may be spoken of openly and what constitute our ‘secrets’, so that many of us maintain a silence about all our involvement in Masonry and thus the suspicions are allowed to grow. All the basic principles of Freemasonry are open; indeed, they only have value because they are universal. The form and content of our rituals are private and to talk of them out of context and to those who have not taken part in them is to invite ridicule and mockery from those who cannot appreciate their solemnity. The secrets of Freemasonry are those signs, words and tokens by which Masons ‘are known to each other.’

'Let a man's religion or mode of worship be what it may, he is not excluded from the order, provided he believe in the glorious architect of heaven and earth, and practise the sacred duties of morality.'
-Antient Charges

Freemasonry has not always been looked upon kindly by those who profess to be religious. In this exhortation, one can begin to see why. Here is truly progressive thought; here is true liberalism; here is a monotheism so inclusive as to put many practitioners of the world's great religions to shame. That any person may draw closer to God, irrespective of any other consideration save that he believe in God and live an upright life according to custom and ability, is a radical thought indeed. It is central to our understanding of Freemasonry and it is, perhaps, one of the greatest gifts that the Craft can give to the world: living proof that people of all races and creeds can join together to work for the common good.

‘It is not enough that in the lodge room or among Freemasons the bond of brotherhood should hold. It is the mission of the craft to spread the gospel of human kinship that all the world will acknowledge the bonds of amity and accord.’

-Anon

The concept of brotherhood is not like a piece of regalia that we put on for our meetings and then put aside until we next come together. While it may be recharged and renewed in Lodge, it must be carried with us into our daily lives and inform all our relationships with others. The lamp that Freemasonry holds up for us is not designed to just illuminate itself, it is to help shed light on all the world. If this, truly, is Freemasonry’s mission, let us once more dedicate ourselves to living out our belief in ‘human kinship’ every day.

'...a poor candidate in a state of darkness.'

-First Degree Ceremony

Although there are practical reasons why a candidate must first enter the Lodge blindfolded, the greater reason, as ever in Freemasonry, is symbolic. Darkness here stands for many things: the fact that we enter Freemasonry not knowing the full extent of its teachings; that we enter this world ignorant of what has come before and what will come after. But, before long, in the course of the ceremony, the blindfold is removed and light is restored. With light comes the knowledge and understanding of direct experience and we are led to appreciate that darkness, or ignorance, is not our proper state. We are born to seek the light, to strive for understanding, and Freemasonry teaches us the beautiful lesson that, in time and with effort, we may all come to understand the truth.

'The earth constantly revolving on its axis in its orbit round the sun, and Freemasonry being universally spread over its surface, it necessarily follows that the sun must always be at its meridian with regard to Freemasonry.'

-Second Degree Ceremony

This is a piece of ritual spoken by every Freemason who has passed through the second degree ceremony. There are two beautiful images here. First of all, the idea that all Masonic ceremonies, contrary to all physical evidence, take place at high noon is symbolic of the fact that Freemasonry is considered always to stand in the Light, with all that symbolises in terms of knowledge, openness and goodness. The second, somewhat inversely, is the fact, inherent in the explanation, that there really are Masonic lodges all over the globe. In many languages, for people of so many creeds, Freemasonry offers a common ground of fellowship and union that transcends even the natural affinity we feel for all that we consider our own. To be part of something so universal is humbling indeed and should serve to help us keep our lives in perspective.

'Men have been imprisoned, tortured and burnt at the stake for defending its teachings.'

-Bible Presentation

Most of us who hear these words live in societies where Freemasonry is able to exist legally and openly and it is no coincidence that these are usually countries that uphold the democratic freedoms. Not all Freemasons are so lucky, however, and it is important that we remember not only their plight, but also the plight of all people whose lives are circumscribed by oppression. Remember, in all ages Freemasonry has been the enemy of every tyranny of religion or politics for the simple reason that it operates on the principle that all people are equal in God's sight. Freemasonry upholds human dignity and strives to create a climate where these basic freedoms can thrive. Such freedoms are very precious. They provide the nutrients for the soil in which the seed of a person's soul can grow and develop. Let us aim to be proud of such a heritage. Let us commit ourselves to strive to be worthy of it.

'...but let me assure you that, in these vows, there is nothing incompatible with your civil, moral or religious duties.'

-First Degree Ceremony

Everything about Freemasonry is designed, not to undermine our sense of social responsibility, but to enhance it, making us 'respectable in life and useful to society.'

The obligations we take are serious and solemn ones but they neither cut us off from society as a whole, nor do they deprive us of our individual freedom. Rather, they stand for us as a commitment to throw in our lot with that of the Order and like any such obligations, such as marriage vows or those for joining a religious order, they provide a bedrock, a foundation, on which we may build the structure of our future selves.

By accepting the constraints of those obligations, we ourselves set the bounds of our daily lives, willingly stepping out on a path that may be narrow, steep and sometimes rocky but which eventually will lead us to our true selves and, beyond, to God.

'He has achieved success who has lived well, laughed often, and loved much...who has left the world better than he found it...who has always looked for the best in others and given the best he had; whose life was an inspiration, whose memory a benediction.'

-Anon

It is easy to get caught up in the trials and tribulations of daily life but it is important that we try always to keep a proper sense of perspective. One of the greatest lessons that Freemasonry teaches is that it encourages us to realise that, while our earthly existence is important, it is short and that, beyond this life, the possibility of a greater, more 'real' life awaits.

To consider our cares, our connections, our hopes, our aspirations and our accomplishments from a perspective beyond this life, to wonder what, really, has been the value of our sojourn on Earth in the face of our certain death, is the mark of wisdom and understanding. All material connections and considerations are, ultimately, temporary and therefore, in a sense, unreal. All that will be left of us will be a memory, so let us determine to ensure that we each live a life that will be an inspiration and a blessing to those who come after us. There is no greater legacy.

'The Sacred Writings are to rule and govern our faith, the square to regulate our actions and the compasses to keep us within due bounds with our Brethren in Freemasonry, as with all mankind.'

-First Degree Ceremony

Faith in God, right conduct and a true understanding of the kinship of humanity may be said to be the three attributes of a good and virtuous person. All three of them are encompassed by the teachings of Freemasonry and from this fact we are able to understand that Freemasonry offers a complete system of living to those who follow its precepts. The symbolism inherent in the Craft, in its three 'great lights', are all that we need to make progress on the path to perfection that we humbly tread. But the fact that the teachings of Freemasonry are 'veiled in allegory and illustrated by symbols' means that we must be prepared to investigate this symbolism in its entirety, not just be content with a shallow and surface understanding. Anything worthwhile needs working at and this is certainly true of Freemasonry. The whole of Masonic ritual is steeped in meaning and any one piece of symbolism or teaching has many levels. Nothing is random or accidental. Remember this as you try to make '...a daily advancement in Masonic knowledge.'

‘...now comes of his own free will and accord, humbly soliciting to be admitted to the mysteries and privileges of ancient Freemasonry.’

-First Degree Ceremony

There are many reasons why Masonry is described as ‘free’ and, because of the multi-layered nature of the Masonic system, they are all true and all teach an important lesson. One of the explanations we are given early on is that it is ‘free’ because ‘...it requires a perfect freedom of inclination in every candidate for its mysteries.’ This is a very important concept because it contains within itself the understanding that there are many paths that lead humanity to the throne of God and that different people approach that throne in different ways. No one path will suit everyone and this is certainly true in the case of Freemasonry. Although we know that its teachings remain relevant to today’s world, we must acknowledge that many of the outer forms and customs of Freemasonry are old-fashioned. Therefore, Freemasonry appeals to many for whom formality of language and action are attractive while others may see it as rather archaic. This is one of the reasons why we have generally been discouraged from soliciting members: because we understand that the path a person treads is a matter best left between them and their God.

'...contemplate on your destiny, and guide your reflections to that most interesting of all human studies, the knowledge of yourself.'

-Third Degree Ceremony

There are so many important lessons wrapped up in the symbolism of the Third Degree that to understand them all would be a lifetime's work in itself. Serious contemplation of our destiny inevitably leads us, with the rest of humanity as our companions, to the brink of the grave. We must then consider what may lie beyond that grave and so it is that the apprehension of our mortality sets us on the rungs of Jacob's ladder: to our faith, our hope that our journey beyond this life will lead us to God and to our understanding that we share these hopes (and their attendant fears) with all humanity, which is the beginning of true charity.

We are taught in Freemasonry that to strive to overcome our baser instincts and sail the boat of this life over the rough seas of passion with equanimity and rectitude is the highest degree of perfection to which a human being can aspire. True self-knowledge is undoubtedly the beginning of wisdom and if we are indeed, in some mystical fashion, made in God's image, understanding ourselves is the first required step to knowing God.

'Your trust being in God, your faith is well founded. Relying on such sure support, you may safely rise and accompany your conductor with a firm but humble confidence, for where the name of God is invoked we trust no danger can ensue.'

-First Degree Ceremony

Having entered the Lodge for the first time and having knelt for prayer, these words are spoken to us before we rise and the ceremony begins in earnest. Obviously, they are spoken to reassure us that we need have no immediate fear about what is to befall us but they have a wider meaning too. They remind us, firstly, that whatever we have got ourselves into with regard to Freemasonry, whoever we associate with in the Craft or outside, ultimately our relationship with God is ours alone and nobody can interfere in it unless we let them. Secondly, the simple faith expressed in the statement is a beautiful and important lesson for us in the whole of our lives, not just within the confines of Freemasonry. So 'firm but humble confidence' is not just the attitude we should adopt in the Lodge; it is not a ritualistic formulation but a true and practical reminder of how we should tread that greater path which is our life on Earth.

'Freemasonry is no longer an exclusive and withdrawn body, doing good by stealth or concerned only for its own. Its principles are blazoned for all men to behold; if now we fail to match fair professions with worthy deeds the fraternity will be brought into contempt and will deserve the condemnation of mankind.'

-Anon

It was not very many years ago that it was decided that Freemasonry should try to be more open about its principles and philosophy. Such a brave decision was absolutely necessary and yet it is fraught with danger. It was necessary, partly because of the negative attention that Freemasonry was once again attracting, but mostly because we had arrived at a crossroads. Either Freemasonry was to become a meaningful force for good in the world, a beacon of light in the gathering darkness of materialism, or it was to drift slowly but irrevocably into a fusty irrelevance, to become a quaint but essentially useless relic of a bygone age. Happily, we chose the former, but the great danger is that the reputation of the Order now lies squarely and wholly on the shoulders of each individual Freemason. The Order can no longer rely on its glorious past to sustain it, it must rely on us. Let us try to do honour to that trust.

‘We hope to arrive at the summit by the assistance of a ladder, called in Scripture, Jacob’s Ladder.’

-First Degree Ceremony

In the lecture on the Tracing Board in this Degree, we are taught that the summit of Freemasonry is reached by the Mason who possesses the virtue of charity ‘in its most exalted sense.’ Charity has several meanings relating to the giving of alms but can also be defined as love of humankind. This, it would seem, is its most exalted sense and so we can begin to understand, even as we first set our feet upon the Masonic path, that our greatest aspiration must be to develop love for our fellow creatures. This love, known to Christians as agape, is founded on the understanding that we are all children of one God. The giving of alms, for which Freemasonry is rightly well known, is, at its best, a physical manifestation of this love.

The Tracing Board teaches us clearly that the path to realisation of brotherly love is through the study of Spiritual teachings and the development and strengthening of all of those three great virtues: Faith, Hope and Love.

'If one advances confidently in the direction of his dreams, and endeavours to live the life which he has imagined, he will meet with a success unexpected in common hours...If you have built castles in the air, your work need not be lost; that is where they should be. Now put the foundations under them.'

-Henry David Thoreau

So much of what we aspire to in Freemasonry seems like an impossible dream. For ourselves we aim to live faultless lives of piety and beneficence although we so easily and often fail to attain it. For humanity we dream of a world of freedom and fairness where brotherly love prevails, yet all around us are poverty, strife and war. We must believe that our dreams are not a waste of time. They are, rather, the ideal that inspires us to keep moving onwards to strive for more, for ourselves and for the world at large. They are the light shining out in the darkness to guide us home.

But the dreams alone are not enough. First come the vision and the inspiration but until we act to bring those dreams to fruition, they will remain out of reach, just 'castles in the air.' Freemasons are builders, although not in stone, but we are dreamers too and we build upwards, to the summit of our dreams, to the very throne of God.

‘The first condition of admission into, and membership of, the Order is a belief in the Supreme Being. This is essential and admits of no compromise.’

-Aims and Relationships of the Craft

As with all paths that lead to Spiritual insight, Freemasonry has had to adapt and change in certain ways to remain relevant and credible in society. The abandoning of the traditional penalties once associated with the Masonic obligations is an example. But, as with all other paths, there are certain basic principles which cannot be altered without changing the very nature of the system. In Freemasonry we refer to these as ‘Landmarks’ and they constitute the very heart and soul of our Craft. The first such landmark, and undoubtedly pre-eminent, is belief in God, whatever we conceive God to be. This is the sure and solid foundation of Freemasonry, for, when all else is stripped away, this one thing can stand alone: that we believe. In many ways it could be argued that this is not the first but, perhaps, the only ‘condition of admission’ that really matters.

'...to look beyond the narrow limits of particular institutions, whether civil or religious, and to view in every son of Adam a brother of the dust.'

-Third Degree Ceremony

Whatever our own private beliefs, religious or political, as Freemasons we are more concerned with actions than with protestations of faith. All Freemasons believe in God; that is the primary condition of membership, but we do not concern ourselves with the details of that belief because we choose to adopt the very widest, most inclusive definition of human kinship as our yardstick. We do recognise that there are differences between people and we understand that different religions and political philosophies seem, at times, hard to reconcile. We could dwell on these differences but that would bring us down to the level of partisanship and one of the greatest messages that Freemasonry teaches is that it is possible to rise above the things that appear to divide us and operate from a higher perspective. Thus we see every man and woman as Brother and Sister and, irrespective of differences between us, we act from the firm conviction that this is so.

'Freemasonry not only inculcates the principles of love and benevolence, it seeks to give them an actual and living presence in all the occupations and intercourse of life. It not only feels, it acts! It not only pities human suffering, it relieves it!'

-Anon

Every lesson that Freemasonry teaches is of practical use in our everyday lives. Although the method of teaching may seem strange to some and, at best, out-dated to others, the fact remains that within our rituals and ceremonies there is to be found the key to living a good and useful life. We do not expect fame and fortune as the world sees it, nor is that something we would particularly value. Our aspiration is to live quietly, humbly, happily, in accord with family, friends and connections; to pursue our careers and jobs with satisfaction, giving our best, and all the time mindful of what is real and what is only temporary. In the second degree ceremony we are encouraged to '...keep eternity in view' and we are encouraged to contemplate our own mortality. Thus our values are, we hope, attuned to the eternal and we act here on Earth in such a way that our beliefs in '...the principles of love and benevolence' are demonstrated in all aspects of our daily lives.

‘...and may He continue to preserve our order by beautifying and adorning us with every moral and social virtue.’

-Closing Ceremony

The reputation of Freemasonry, the power it has to be a force for good in the world, even its very existence is in the hands of every Freemason. If we are to be open about our membership of the Order, we must also accept the responsibility to be its ambassadors. It is far easier, of course, to keep silent and only own to being a Mason among other Masons. But what message does that give to the world, to our families and even to our inner selves? That we are ashamed of what we profess to admire? That Masonry has no value beyond being a self-serving clique?

If we truly believe that Freemasonry has any worth in the world, we must also believe that we are of worth to Freemasonry. The ritual makes it clear here that the survival of the Order is inextricably linked with the behaviour of every Mason. It is by our demonstration of ‘every moral and social virtue’ that the Craft will be preserved. Let us continue to pray daily that we may be so ‘beautified and adorned.’

Afterword:

If you have enjoyed this book, perhaps you would be good enough to review it in your favourite eBookstore.

You may also be interested in these titles by the same author:

‘Hidden Depths: 100 Daily Meditations for Royal Arch Companions.’

‘Teaching from the Heart: 100 Meditations for Teachers.’

All titles are also available in print.

For more information please e-mail:

jonti.marks@gmail.com

www.masonicmeditations.com

<http://meditationsforteachers.wordpress.com/>